how do Indian policymakers debate and implement policies on issues of material and ideational, as well as regional and global importance, in the light of these contradictions? Even though India's rise, combined with that of China, is altering the vocabulary of international politics, the answer to this question is still being explored. This book intends to decode India's foreign policy-making processes and add to a growing body of literature on this topic, by examining the widely discussed and strategically important, but grossly understudied and routinely misunderstood subject of India's approach towards Afghanistan since the Soviet invasion to the ongoing US withdrawal. The central question that concerns this book is: is containing Pakistan a key factor driving India's Afghanistan policy?

A fulcrum of global power play for decades, and a theatre of conflict, competition, as well as aspiration, Afghanistan is of critical strategic interest for India, and captures the magnitude and multitude of changes in India's foreign and security policy over the years. Situated in the heart of Asia, Afghanistan marked, if not caused, the sudden dramatic dissolution of the Soviet Union and an end to the Cold War. Then, instead of being sidelined to the margins of history, it emerged as the first frontier of the tragically termed, poorly understood, and ruthlessly executed, global war on terror. Witnessing war for more than thirty-five years including various military interventions, first by the Soviet Union, then by Pakistan (or Pakistan-supported elements), and the latest by the US-led NATO forces, Afghanistan has also seen the rise and fall of at least three ideologies (communism, radical Islam, and liberal democracy), within a short span of fifty years. Given its unfortunate history, Afghanistan came to be understood more as a buffer space where external powers play 'great games'—a term coined for the benefit of the British Raj, but which stubbornly persists to date.[3]

In 2011, then US Secretary of State and later presidential candidate Hillary Clinton espoused a regional solution to the unending conflict in Afghanistan.[4] Aiming to develop Afghanistan as a 'neutral' territory, Clinton equated today's Afghanistan with early nineteenth-century Europe. She hoped that South Asian countries would reach an agreement similar to the 1814–15 Congress of Vienna after the French defeat in the Napoleonic wars. Leading to the creation of a neutral zone in the Benelux countries, the Congress of Vienna model marked a